

THE HAPPINESS ISSUE

ering crop fields—in the steep terrain in the past 15 months. Functioning within the ambit of the central polyhouse subsidy scheme, this was achieved without the farmers having to pay the mandatory half the total cost. Before Gupta shone the light, farmers had to work as domestic helps or labourers for nine months of the year since the farming season lasted for only three months. In the past 15 months, with the polyhouses insulating them from inclement/ cold weather, around 2,500 farmer families have been able to farm for nine months.

The transformation in their fortune began around two years back, when Gupta was on tour to take stock of his department's work and was staying in Todey-Tangta, a hamlet in Bengal's Kalimpong district. A few farmers came knocking on his door one evening. "These were very poor horticulture farmers," Gupta reminisces. The men came looking for government schemes and benefits.

Under the Union government's Mission for Integrated Development for Horticulture (MIDH), the state provides polyhouses to horticulturists at a 50 per cent subsidised rate. But Gupta faced an impasse: the farmers were too poor to pay anything. For the mountainous terrain of North Bengal, 100 sq. m. polyhouses are most suitable, with each such unit estimated to cost around Rs 45, 000.

"They wanted the polyhouse for free. But the department couldn't go against MIDH norms," says Gupta. Unwilling to disappoint the farmers, the horticulture department officials looked for a way out. After much deliberation, Gupta and his associates cracked the puzzle. North Bengal being abundant in bamboo, farmers had enough raw material for polyhouses. The department then organised training programmes for horticulturists on setting up polyhouses—thus saving on the substantial expense of hiring contractors. Thus, farmers' mandatory share could be realised from him in terms of bamboo and labour, instead of cash. The department provided construction materials for the polyhouse too—cladding material, shade nets, drip irrigation kit, nails, channels, wires, pulleys, etc. Thus the mutated version of the central scheme, christened the "Do It Yourself (DIY)" kit, was born. Through Gupta's initiative, the department didn't have to go against MIDH norms, and farmers now have a higher yield and better income.

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HAPPINESS QUOTIENT

↘ Gupta tweaked a central scheme to help horticulture farmers in the hills of Darjeeling and Kalimpong districts multiply their produce

↘ In the past 15 months, 2,513 polyhouses have come up in Kalimpong and Darjeeling, turning things around for 2,500 farmer families

↘ Horticulturists supplied bamboo and labour, while the department gave them other material for polyhouses

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Gupta has overseen the geo-tagging of Darjeeling Mandarin Orange trees, and started an orange festival

From none before, 2,513 DIY polyhouses have come up in the districts of Kalimpong and Darjeeling in the past 15 months . Another 415 kits have been requisitioned for distribution.

Beenu Sherpa, 44, a horticulturist in Sitong I block in Darjeeling, claims that her income has more than doubled since she availed the tweaked polyhouse scheme. "Earlier, we could grow one or two crops at a time and only for a maximum of three months in a year. Now we grow something or the other round the year for nine-10 months," she tells INDIA TODAY. "I grow chilli, broccoli, tomato, potato, cabbage, cauliflower and several other crops. Wild animals cannot get to them inside the polyhouse," Sherpa adds.

"I have never seen such a massive acceptance for a government scheme before," says Gupta. "Because of the conducive weather of Darjeeling and Kalimpong, the cultivation of vegetables, flowers and decorative plants can benefit from these polyhouses." The former managing director of the West Bengal Industrial development Corporation and the Kolkata Metro Rail Corporation Ltd refuses to stop at polyhouses. In the past one year, he has overseen the geotagging of more than 1,000 plants of the Darjeeling Mandarin Orange variety. While once this variety of orange was sold at a high price across the globe, its production has gone down in recent decades. The department has started an orange festival in Mungpoo in Darjeeling from 2022 to encourage farmers to get back to orange farming. ■